



Crucible Education Centre
General Paper
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GENERAL PAPER: GOVERNANCE INFOPACK



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Governance

Countries' methods of governance are shaped by a range of historical and socio-economic factors.

- Whatever the choice may be in method of governance, there will be pros & cons, effects & consequences on the people, economically and socially.

Governance is about negotiation between tensions. These tensions can happen on multiple levels.

- The tension between individual freedom and social stability always requires compromise.
- The tension between individual freedom and the amount of power vested in the state always requires compromise.
- The tension between the needs of the majority and that of the minority always requires compromise.
- The tension between how resources are managed and allocated over the long term and the short term always requires compromise
- The tension between domestic interests and global pressures always require compromise.

The increasing influence of the media on society has an impact on governance.

The media can shape the public's perceptions of and behaviour towards political actors/institutions, consequentially aiding or hindering governance.



Theme 1: Democracy

Democracy refers to a society's right to elect its own government, usually through the form of an electoral vote held during a general elections.

- Democracy is government by the people, which may either be direct, when citizens participate directly in ruling, or representative when citizens delegate power to elect representatives in a congress or parliament.
- Today's democracies are representative democracies, in which voters select their favoured representatives.

Issue 1: Justifications for democracy

- **Freedom and equality:** Democracy is expressive of two values we hold dear: freedom and equality. Freedom is a matter of giving people a say in political decision-making, particularly those decisions that affect them. Equality lies in this freedom being given to all
- **Minority protection:** The constitution can be designed to limit the scope of majority rule in such a way as to protect minorities. For instance, the constitution may contain a list of rights every citizen must enjoy: a proposed law or policy decision that would infringe one of these rights will be thrown out as unconstitutional. Any minority then has the assurance that whatever the majority decides cannot violate one of their basic rights as laid down in the constitution.
- Criticisms for democracy
 - **Political participation:** While democracy is often celebrated as a method of giving all citizens a share in political decision-making, it is often cited that democracy merely provides an illusory sense of participation in political decision-making.
 - Democracies give their citizens only a very limited role in government. They are entitled to vote at periodic elections, they are occasionally consulted through a referendum when some major constitutional question has to be decided, and they are allowed to form groups to lobby their representatives on issues that concern them, but that is the extent of their authority.
 - Some voters may not understand where their best interests lie, or may be duped by skilful speech-makers.
 - **Tyranny of the majority:** Dominant social and economic groups are at an advantage because they can put forward their preferences and opinions as 'authoritative knowledge' and in the process devalue those with alternative beliefs, preferences and interests.



- **Voters' ignorance:** Critics of democracy, most notably Plato, have pointed out that sound political decision-making requires a great deal of expertise, expertise which many voters do not have. In a *representative democracy*, many voters aren't in a position to assess the suitability of a particular candidate. Since they aren't in a position to assess political policy, they may choose their representatives on the basis of non-relevant attributes or that their voting is determined by unexamined prejudices about political parties. (shows the importance of having EDUCATED voters).



Theme 2: Responsibilities of the government

The government that governs the people is often tasked with multiple responsibilities. The main role of the government is to improve the standard of living and the quality of lives of its people through the implementation of various governmental policies.

Issue 1: Government's economic responsibility

- The government should develop the economy because this builds a stable nation. A good economy leads to political stability, and vice versa.
- This allows for the implementation of long-term policies that further the progress of the nation.
- With a better economy come better public facilities and amenities, infrastructure, and education. It will lead to a higher standard of living and most people will lead a happier life.
- A good economy is crucial if a country is to be governed well. It gives the government the political and financial means to implement policies which address other aspects of society, such as the environment. An economically insecure country cannot afford things which threaten to destabilise the country, such as additional opposition parties. A good economy thus paves the way for the government to start respecting a greater number of freedoms.
- **BUT should not sacrifice quality of life for economic growth**
 - With rapid economic growth comes greater income disparity – the government should take steps to ensure that this does not happen.
 - According to the IMF, India is the world's seventh largest economy with fast economic growth, but it is one of the bottom countries on the HDI. It is ranked 130th out of 186 countries on the 2015 Human Development Index (HDI), below developing economies such as Brazil and China. Wealth is not equally spread within the country, with Kerala and Delhi being the states with the best quality of life. 29.8% of Indians, however, live below the poverty line.
 - Singapore's Gini Coefficient rating (0.410 in 2015) is one of the highest in the world. Critics have pointed out that Singapore's breakneck pace of economic growth has left the uneducated and unskilled in the dust. While the government cannot be accused of doing nothing to relieve the plight of the less wealthy, this is a major issue which opposition parties are only too happy to capitalise upon.
- **BUT should not always encourage economic progress at the cost of the environment.**
 - China is notorious for its industrial pollution. Although China has one of the highest rates of economic growth in the world, 16 of the world's 20 most polluted cities are in China. 40% of China's lakes and water sources are contaminated with chemicals from factories, and China is the world's largest emitter of carbon dioxide. Numerous species have gone extinct in China, most notable amongst them being the Yangtze River Dolphin.



Issue 2: Government's role in citizens' personal lives/Social Issues

- **The government should intervene in our personal lives only when it leads to the betterment of society as a whole. It has the duty to do so when it comes to matters of national security.**
 - The privacy of individuals has to be occasionally encroached upon for the safety of the country.
- **The government should also intervene if this helps to ameliorate the problems of poverty, low literacy rates, and unsanitary living conditions.**
 - In Singapore, the government introduced the Electronic Road Pricing Scheme— an electronic toll collection scheme in 1998 – and the Certificate of Entitlement Scheme (COE) to manage traffic. Though initially unpopular, these have served to regulate the amount of traffic on Singapore's roads. According to the Land Transport Authority (LTA), there are now fewer traffic jams and noise/air pollution as more Singaporeans have turned to public transport.
 - To spur economic growth and preserve ethnic heritage, the educational policy of bilingualism was implemented in 1966. Most students are required to take a Mother Tongue subject while English was promoted as the lingua franca among the diverse ethnic groups in Singapore. This helped to maintain racial harmony in Singapore while allowing Singapore to attain a high literacy rate (96.5% in 2013).
- **The government should not adopt a totalitarian approach when it comes to personal freedoms – it will violate our freedom of choice/expression/speech and will eventually build resentment towards the government.**
 - US Patriot Act (2001) – While there have been successes since its implementation,
 - it has been heavily criticized for allowing the government to violate the privacy of its citizens – it allows certain national agencies (FBI, CIA, and NSA) to search private phone, email, and financial records without a court order. It also allows for wiretapping and the tracking of individuals via GPS systems. It also allows for the detention of any foreign person (“alien”) who is believed to be planning to carry out terrorist attack. In September 2003, it was reported by the New York Times that the Act was being used to investigate possible drug traffickers without probable cause, and in 2005, to obtain one million financial records of customers of targeted Las Vegas businesses.

Issue 3: Government's role vis-à-vis the media

- **The government should regulate the media when it concerns matters of national security.**
 - If the media has the potential to incite national instability and cause civil unrest, the government should also intervene.



- The media should also be held in check when it provides information that threatens the safety of the country.
- Example: WikiLeaks is an international, non-profit, online portal that publishes classified information, news leaks, and media from anonymous sources. Access to WikiLeaks is blocked at the United States Library of Congress, and all unauthorized government workers/contractors are banned from accessing WikiLeaks documents. WikiLeaks has been accused of threatening national security and the safety of US army soldiers as more than 90,000 classified military documents have been leaked.
- **The government should make effort to censor programmes that contain immoral or unethical content, while encouraging those that benefit society.**
 - Singapore example – In 2013, the extramarital affair website Ashley Madison was banned from Singapore (and South Korea) as the Singapore government felt that it could not accept the immoral values that the website seems to encourage.
- **The government should not control what the media says in order to retain their hold on power.**
 - The media is the fourth estate. It provides information that the government might choose to withhold and thus helps to ensure a degree of transparency within the government, keeping it in check.
- **The government should not use the media for propaganda to further its own aims.**
 - All news and information in North Korea go through the North Korean Central News Agency, where it is heavily edited and censored. Internet access is illegal in North Korea, and radio/television sets are pre-set to be tuned into only government frequencies. The censorship of the media has led to the creation of a personality cult revolving around the Kim Family.



Issue 4: Government's role vis-à-vis the international community (International relations/affairs)

- **When there are environmental issues that threaten the regional community or a humanitarian crisis, the government should be obliged to extend an offer of aid to other countries.**
- **Military intervention is justified when rogue nations act to destabilise the international community or when there is on- going abuse of human rights.**
 - Yugoslav Wars – The North Atlantic Treaty Organization was forced to intervene with a bombing campaign when the Yugoslav government refused to end hostilities and rejected the idea of an external peacekeeping force during the Kosovo War in 1999. While it caused the death of 2,000 civilians and injured thousands more, it can be argued that this intervention was justified as it resulted in a complete end to all hostilities in the region. The Yugoslav government agreed to withdraw its forces from Kosovo and allow an external peacekeeping force to enter the country, preventing more lives from being lost in the conflict.
- **The government should not use legitimate reasons as a pretext for it to further its ulterior motives when it comes to another country.**

For example, political events such as the large protests in 1999 at the Seattle WTO meeting or in 2001 at the G8 meeting in Genoa, Italy, have led some political leaders to conclude that certain kinds of market interventions or regulations are necessary to assist those who are endangered by globalization, simply to sustain political support for continued liberalization. Hence, governments that decide to intervene should not use intervention as a reason to impose their political will onto other countries.

Since 2005, the Angolan government has borrowed billions of US dollars from China, Brazil, Portugal, Germany, Spain and the European Union (EU) to help rebuild Angola's **infrastructure**. However, it has been argued that this has led to a loss of sovereignty for Angola, and difficulties in implementation of policy.

The Gambia benefitted from considerable multilateral debt relief from the International Monetary Fund (IMF), the World Bank and the African Development Fund after reaching the Highly Indebted Poor Countries (HIPC) completion point (a list of specific conditions) in December 2007. Similarly, this has arguably led to a loss of governmental sovereignty for Gambia, as its citizens view the IMF and the ADF as its governing bodies for the influx of foreign aid.

In July 2015, the World Bank supported new lending guidelines for power projects that limit investment in coal-fired power plants and increase **concessional long-term loans** for hydroelectric power. This policy is controversial for two reasons. Firstly, coal-fired power generation has traditionally been the cheapest electricity source for poor countries. Secondly, not all US politicians believe that emissions



cause changes to the climate and the **US provides most of the World Bank's funds.**

- **The government should not involve itself in other matters if it is financially unable to do so.**



General examples on Democracy & Corruption

- In the United Kingdom, the Prevention of Corruption Act makes it an offence for “any person to give a consideration to an agent to induce him to act in relation to his principal affair”. Such anti-corruption legislature is present in the constitution of other mature democracies such as the United States of America.
- In Indonesia, Suharto revoked the independence of the judicial body after implementing his “New Order” which was essentially a personal dictatorship. There was massive corruption during his presidency, with his personal friends and family members being appointed to positions of power. Global Corruption Reports by Transparency International have ranked Suharto as one of its all-time worst examples of how corruption crippled developing nations.
- In 2013, the first democratically elected President of Egypt, Mohamed Morsi, was deposed by the Egyptian military following prolonged mass protests against his increasingly authoritarian rule. Morsi’s unceremonious demise took many by surprise, as his election in 2012 was hailed as a historic moment in Egyptian history, marking the start of the democratisation process in Egypt. However, Morsi’s fall, the violence that preceded and followed it, and his turbulent one-year rule ultimately serve as harsh reminders that a functioning democracy simply does not emerge overnight.
- Democracy can well lead to populism. Politicians may act in a way that is popular and well accepted by the people, but not best for the state. Politicians also tend to work towards short-term goods for the country and focus more on winning the next election as opposed to benefitting the country in the long run. In the cold war era, an important reason between the escalating tensions between the US and Soviet Russia was due to the harsh actions taken by the US, which was considered aggressive by the Russians. However, this aggressive stance taken by the US was actually prompted by the need for the government to reassure the American citizens, at the expense of further misunderstanding by the USSR. (Default of democracy)
- When the voices of the people and the voices of politicians who claim to represent them grow too loud and strident, or worse, when the democratic liberties are taken to extremes and violence erupts, a country can be paralysed or worse, torn apart. An example would be the massive political upheaval and turbulence in Thailand from 2008 to 2010. As Thais “enjoy” a high degree of freedom of assembly, protesters wearing red or yellow shirts, depending on which political faction they supported, staged massive rallies and even blockaded important public buildings such as the airport and parliament. Street rallies often turned violent and the streets of Bangkok descended into chaos and bloodshed. Hundreds were killed and thousands injured.



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HOW GOVERNMENTS AND THEIR COUNTRIES' DEVELOPMENT ARE MEASURED

Overall Economic Development/Standard of Living

Human Development Index (HDI)	• A composite statistic of life expectancy, education, and income indices used to rank countries • In 2010 an Inequality-adjusted Human Development Index (IHDI) was introduced. • While the simple HDI remains useful, the IHDI is the actual level of human development (accounting for inequality)
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Economic development/ Financial stability

Gross Domestic Product (GDP)	• One of the primary indicators to gauge the health of a country's economy • It represents the total dollar value of all goods and services produced over a specific time period • serves as an indicator of economic growth and production
Income per capita	• A measure of the amount of money that is being earned per person in a certain area • Cannot account for income inequality
Gini Coefficient	• Measures the extent to which the distribution of income or consumption expenditure among individuals or households within an economy deviates from a perfectly equal distribution • A Gini coefficient of 0 represents perfect equality, while a Gini coefficient of 1 implies perfect inequality.

Level of corruption

Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI)	• The Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI) is an annual ranking of countries by their perceived levels of corruption, as determined by expert assessments and opinion surveys. • The CPI generally defines corruption as the misuse of public power for private benefit. The CPI measures perception of corruption due to the difficulty of measuring absolute levels of corruption. • The CPI currently ranks 168 countries and territories on a scale from 100 (very clean) to 0 (highly corrupt). • Singapore ranks 4th in the CPI Index, as being the 4th least corrupt country in the world rankings.
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Education

Trends in International Mathematics and Science Study(TIMSS)	An international assessment of the mathematics and science knowledge of 4th and 8th grader (loosely, ages 9/10 and 13/14, respectively) students around the world.
Program for International Student Assessment (PISA)	- An international assessment that measures 15-year-old students' reading, mathematics, and science literacy - Run every three years by the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development
University ranking	QS World University Rankings - An annual university ranking published by Quacquarelli Symonds (QS) which provides overall rankings as well as rankings for individual subjects Times Higher Education (THE) World University Rankings - An annual world university ranking published by the British magazine Times Higher Education (THE) with data supplied by Thomson Reuters - Includes both the overall and the subject rankings. Academic Ranking of World Universities (ARWU) [also known as the Shanghai Ranking] - Founded and compiled by the Shanghai Jiao Tong University - Its consistent and objective methodology is praised when compared with other rankings. - However, it has also been criticized for its heavier focus on the natural sciences over the social sciences or humanities, and on research over the quality of instruction

Happiness

Happy Planet Index (HPI)	- The index is weighted to give progressively higher scores to nations with lower ecological footprints. - Measures the extent to which countries deliver long, happy, sustainable lives for the people that live in them. - Designed to challenge well-established indices of countries' development, such as Gross Domestic Product (GDP) and the Human Development Index (HDI), which are seen as not taking sustainability into account.
Gross National	Designed in an attempt to define an indicator and concept that measures quality of life or social progress in more holistic and



Happiness (GNH)	psychological terms than only the economic indicator of gross domestic product (GDP). • GNH has only been officially used in Bhutan, which is used to measure the collective happiness and well-being of a population.
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